

SUNO PROMPTING

FIELD GUIDE

A practical handbook for genre, instrumentation, vocals, effects, structure, lyrics, and iteration

This guide treats prompting as musical direction. It converts references into concrete choices about rhythm, harmony, arrangement, performance, and production.

Use this guide to	Outcome
Build a style prompt	Specify the sound in an order Suno can follow
Translate an artist reference	Describe traits without naming or copying the artist
Control lyrics and sections	Use readable lyric blocks and restrained section cues
Diagnose weak generations	Change one prompt layer at a time
Create experimental work	Combine unusual meter, timbre, form, and vocal direction

Edition: September 2026
Scope: Suno v6 family and current creation tools

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1. The prompting mental model

Suno does not execute a score or a production specification. It interprets text as a bundle of musical associations and generates a plausible song. Specific controls such as model choice, vocal gender, Exclude, and sliders are explicit product features. Most descriptive terms remain probabilistic directions rather than commands.[1][2][3][4]

The strongest prompts describe audible behavior. A genre label establishes the neighborhood. Tempo and groove establish motion. Instruments define the ensemble. Vocal descriptors define the performer. Arrangement terms describe energy over time. Production terms describe distance, space, density, and finish.

The six-layer model

Layer	Question	Examples
Genre and era	What musical language should dominate?	art rock, 1970s progressive rock, modern alt-pop
Tempo and groove	How should time feel?	92 BPM, swung pocket, urgent 7/8 pulse
Instrumentation	Who is playing?	baritone guitar, analog synth, upright bass, brushed drums
Voice and delivery	Who is singing and how?	intimate contralto, theatrical baritone, breathy close-mic vocal
Arrangement	How should energy develop?	sparse verse, rising pre-chorus, explosive final chorus
Production	What should the recording feel like?	dry drums, wide guitars, tape saturation, dark room reverb

Control is a hierarchy

- Start with one dominant genre. Add one secondary influence only when it performs a clear job.
- Name the most important instrument, vocal character, and energy arc before decorative effects.
- Put global directions in Style. Put lyrics and restrained section cues in Lyrics.
- Use Exclude for unwanted instruments or traits instead of repeatedly saying what you do not want.[4]
- Generate several candidates. Prompting changes probabilities, not certainties.

Rule of thumb: if a phrase cannot be heard, played, sung, arranged, or mixed, it is probably too abstract. Replace 'innovative' with 'abrupt meter changes and granular vocal edits.' Replace 'epic' with 'rising strings, massed drums, choir, and a final-key-change climax.'

2. A reliable prompt architecture

A consistent order makes prompts easier to debug. Suno does not publish a required syntax, but the following sequence separates high-level identity from detailed execution.

GENRE + ERA + TEMPO/GROOVE + INSTRUMENTS + VOCAL + ARRANGEMENT + PRODUCTION + ENDING

Compact formula

Avant-prog and art pop, 104 BPM with alternating 7/8 and 4/4, angular clean guitar, elastic distorted bass, dry acoustic drums, theatrical baritone shifting into whispered harmonies, sparse verses and an explosive final refrain, close-mic vocals, crisp transients, spectral reverb, hard stop.

Why each clause exists

Clause	High-value content	Common mistake
Genre	One primary and one compatible secondary genre	Listing six genres with no hierarchy
Era	A production period or scene	Using a decade without audible traits
Tempo	BPM plus feel when important	Assuming BPM alone defines groove
Instruments	Three to five foreground instruments	Naming an entire orchestra
Voice	Range, texture, delivery, ensemble role	Only specifying male or female
Arrangement	Contrast between sections and final destination	Describing mood but not development
Production	A few audible mix traits	Stacking contradictory studio adjectives
Ending	Hard stop, fade, unresolved sustain, or instrumental coda	Leaving endings entirely implicit

Prompt density

Density	When to use	Typical result
Minimal	Discovery and broad ideation	More model initiative and larger variation
Focused	Most finished generations	Clear identity with room for musical decisions
Dense	Unusual forms or precise ensembles	More control, but greater risk of ignored or blended details
Contradictory	Intentional surrealism	Unpredictable hybrids and unstable emphasis

Best default: 6 to 10 meaningful clauses. Each clause should control a different musical dimension. Repetition rarely increases obedience and often dilutes the prompt.

3. Genre atlas

Genre terms provide dense bundles of rhythm, instrumentation, harmony, vocal behavior, and production history. The effect column describes the tendency a term usually adds. Artist names are listening references, not suggested prompt text.

Rock, punk, and metal

Term	Listening references	Likely influence
Classic rock	Led Zeppelin, The Who	riff-driven guitars, live drums, blues-derived swagger
Progressive rock	Yes, Genesis, Rush	long forms, odd meters, instrumental development
Avant-prog	King Crimson, Henry Cow	dissonance, angular riffs, abrupt structural turns
Math rock	Battles, Don Caballero	interlocking patterns, clean articulation, irregular meter
Art rock	David Bowie, Roxy Music	theatrical presentation, conceptual writing, unusual colors
Psychedelic rock	Pink Floyd, Jimi Hendrix	swirling effects, extended passages, altered-space atmosphere
Krautrock	Can, Neu!	motorik repetition, hypnotic bass, experimental electronics
Post-rock	Mogwai, Explosions in the Sky	instrumental arcs, delay guitars, large crescendos
Alternative rock	R.E.M., Pixies	guitar-centered songs with non-mainstream textures
Indie rock	The Strokes, Arcade Fire	direct band sound, personal vocals, scene-specific character
Grunge	Nirvana, Soundgarden	raw vocals, heavy guitars, loud-soft contrast
Shoegaze	My Bloody Valentine, Slowdive	dense guitar haze, buried vocals, wide ambience
Dream pop	Cocteau Twins, Beach House	soft vocals, suspended harmony, luminous guitars
Post-punk	Joy Division, Wire	angular guitar, prominent bass, controlled tension
New wave	Blondie, Devo	tight pop forms, bright synths, clipped rhythm guitar
Gothic rock	The Cure, Siouxsie and the Banshees	dark bass, chorus guitar, dramatic atmosphere
Garage rock	The Sonics, The White Stripes	simple riffs, loose performance, raw distortion
Noise rock	Sonic Youth, Lightning Bolt	abrasion, feedback, unstable rhythm
Hardcore punk	Black Flag, Minor Threat	fast tempos, shouted vocals, compressed aggression
Post-hardcore	Fugazi, At the Drive-In	punk intensity with dynamic and rhythmic complexity
Pop-punk	Green Day, Blink-182	fast power chords, melodic hooks, youthful vocals
Emo	Sunny Day Real Estate, Jimmy Eat World	confessional vocals, dynamic guitar build
Glam rock	T. Rex, early Queen	theatrical hooks, stomping beats, bright guitars
Stoner rock	Kyuss, Queens of the Stone Age	low-tuned riffs, dry desert tone, heavy groove
Doom metal	Candlemass, Electric Wizard	slow weight, sustained riffs, ominous scale choices
Heavy metal	Judas Priest, Iron Maiden	distorted riffs, forceful vocals, driving drums
Thrash metal	Metallica, Slayer	fast palm-muted guitars, aggressive drums, sharp attacks
Death metal	Death, Morbid Angel	growled vocals, dense riffs, blast beats
Black metal	Mayhem, Emperor	tremolo guitar, shrieked vocals, cold lo-fi atmosphere
Progressive metal	Tool, Dream Theater	complex meter, long arrangements, precise heaviness
Djent	Meshuggah, Periphery	syncopated low guitar, mechanical precision, polymetric feel
Industrial metal	Nine Inch Nails, Ministry	machine rhythm, metallic noise, processed aggression

Term	Listening references	Likely influence
Nu metal	Korn, Deftones	downtuned groove, hip-hop influence, emotional vocal contrast
Metalcore	Killswitch Engage, Converge	heavy breakdowns, screamed verses, melodic choruses

Pop, soul, funk, and singer-songwriter

Term	Listening references	Likely influence
Contemporary pop	Dua Lipa, Harry Styles	clean hooks, compact form, polished production
Art pop	Kate Bush, Bjork	experimental arrangements with strong vocal identity
Synth-pop	Pet Shop Boys, CHVRCHES	synth hooks, electronic drums, concise choruses
Electropop	Robyn, Lady Gaga	club-ready electronic production and pop songwriting
Hyperpop	SOPHIE, 100 geecs	maximal processing, pitch shifts, abrupt digital contrast
Chamber pop	Sufjan Stevens, The Divine Comedy	strings, woodwinds, detailed acoustic arranging
Baroque pop	The Left Banke, Weyes Blood	ornate harmony, harpsichord or strings, stately motion
Power pop	Big Star, Cheap Trick	bright guitars, compact melodies, energetic choruses
Bubblegum pop	The Archies, Aqua	simple hooks, bright timbres, playful repetition
Sophisti-pop	Sade, Prefab Sprout	smooth jazz harmony, elegant production, restrained vocals
Dance-pop	Madonna, Kylie Minogue	steady dance beat, immediate hook, bright synth layers
Disco	Chic, Donna Summer	four-on-the-floor kick, octave bass, strings, rhythmic guitar
Funk	James Brown, Parliament	syncopated bass, short guitar attacks, groove priority
P-funk	Parliament-Funkadelic, Bootsy Collins	rubbery bass, sci-fi synths, comic theatricality
Soul	Aretha Franklin, Otis Redding	gospel-derived emotion, horns, rhythm-section warmth
Neo-soul	Erykah Badu, D'Angelo	behind-the-beat pocket, rich chords, intimate vocals
Contemporary R&B	SZA, The Weeknd	layered vocals, electronic low end, atmospheric harmony
Quiet storm	Anita Baker, Luther Vandross	slow polished groove, warm electric piano, smooth vocals
Gospel	Mahalia Jackson, Kirk Franklin	choir, call and response, rising emotional intensity
Acoustic singer-songwriter	Joni Mitchell, Nick Drake	lyric focus, fingerstyle guitar, intimate room
Piano ballad	Carole King, Adele	voice-forward arrangement, gradual dynamic build
Yacht rock	Toto, Steely Dan	smooth harmony, clean guitars, polished rhythm section
City pop	Mariya Takeuchi, Tatsuro Yamashita	bright fusion harmony, polished bass, urban nostalgia

Electronic and club music

Term	Listening references	Likely influence
Ambient	Brian Eno, Stars of the Lid	slow evolution, texture, spaciousness, little percussion
Dark ambient	Lustmord, Tim Hecker	low drones, degraded space, ominous movement
IDM	Aphex Twin, Autechre	complex electronic rhythm, abstraction, detailed sound design
Glitch	Oval, Alva Noto	clicks, skips, fragmentation, digital failure aesthetics
Glitch pop	The Postal Service, Dntel	melodic songwriting with chopped electronic details
Indietronica	Caribou, Hot Chip	live-instrument warmth blended with electronics
Trip-hop	Massive Attack, Portishead	slow breakbeats, deep bass, cinematic melancholy

Term	Listening references	Likely influence
Downtempo	Bonobo, Thievery Corporation	relaxed programmed beats and atmospheric layers
House	Frankie Knuckles, Marshall Jefferson	four-on-the-floor beat, piano or organ stabs
Deep house	Larry Heard, Kerri Chandler	warm bass, soulful chords, restrained club energy
Progressive house	Sasha, Deadmau5	long builds, layered arpeggios, gradual releases
Acid house	Phuture, 808 State	resonant squelching bass and repetitive club rhythm
Techno	Juan Atkins, Jeff Mills	machine pulse, repetition, synthetic percussion
Detroit techno	Derrick May, Underground Resistance	futurist chords, driving machines, soulful restraint
Minimal techno	Richie Hawtin, Robert Hood	few elements, precise repetition, subtle evolution
Trance	Paul van Dyk, Above & Beyond	arpeggios, long builds, euphoric harmonic release
Drum and bass	Goldie, Roni Size	fast breakbeats, sub-bass, kinetic momentum
Jungle	Shy FX, LTJ Bukem	chopped breaks, reggae bass influence, rapid rhythmic edits
Breakbeat	The Chemical Brothers, Plump DJs	syncopated drum loops, heavy sampled energy
UK garage	MJ Cole, Artful Dodger	shuffled drums, chopped vocals, elastic bass
Dubstep	Skream, Burial	half-time pulse, sub-bass, sparse or dark atmospheres
Future garage	Burial, Synkro	ghostly vocal chops, rain-soaked ambience, swung percussion
Electro	Afrika Bambaataa, Drexciya	syncopated drum-machine funk and robotic synths
Electroclash	Fischerspooner, Peaches	cold synths, punk attitude, spoken vocals
Synthwave	Kavinsky, Com Truise	1980s synth colors, gated drums, cinematic nostalgia
Vaporwave	Macintosh Plus, Saint Pepsi	slowed samples, glossy nostalgia, surreal repetition
Chiptune	Anamanaguchi, Chipzel	8-bit waveforms, rapid arpeggios, game-like melody
Industrial	Throbbing Gristle, Einsturzende Neubauten	metallic noise, loops, confrontational texture
EBM	Front 242, Nitzer Ebb	sequenced bass, commanding vocals, rigid dance pulse
Drone	Sunn O))), Eliane Radigue	sustained tones, gradual spectral change, minimal rhythm
Musique concrete	Pierre Schaeffer, Pierre Henry	collaged recorded sounds, abstraction, tape logic

Hip-hop, jazz, folk, country, and global traditions

Term	Listening references	Likely influence
Boom bap	DJ Premier, Pete Rock	hard drums, sampled loops, direct rap pocket
Trap	T.I., Future	808 bass, rapid hi-hats, sparse minor-key atmosphere
Drill	Chief Keef, Pop Smoke	sliding bass, dark harmony, clipped rhythmic delivery
Lo-fi hip-hop	Nujabes, J Dilla	dusty samples, relaxed drums, imperfect timing
Alternative hip-hop	OutKast, De La Soul	unusual samples, flexible structures, playful delivery
Jazz rap	A Tribe Called Quest, Digable Planets	jazz samples, conversational flow, warm bass
Old-school hip-hop	Run-D.M.C., Grandmaster Flash	drum-machine clarity, call and response
Jazz	Miles Davis, John Coltrane	improvisation, extended harmony, interactive rhythm
Bebop	Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie	fast lines, complex chords, agile rhythm section
Cool jazz	Chet Baker, Dave Brubeck	restrained dynamics, clear space, sophisticated harmony
Hard bop	Art Blakey, Horace Silver	blues and gospel energy, forceful acoustic ensemble

Term	Listening references	Likely influence
Modal jazz	Miles Davis, McCoy Tyner	open harmony, pedal tones, exploratory solos
Free jazz	Ornette Coleman, Cecil Taylor	collective improvisation, unstable form, dissonance
Jazz fusion	Weather Report, Mahavishnu Orchestra	electric instruments, virtuosity, rock rhythm
Big band	Duke Ellington, Count Basie	brass sections, arranged hits, swing propulsion
Bossa nova	Joao Gilberto, Antonio Carlos Jobim	soft syncopation, nylon guitar, intimate voice
Samba	Cartola, Jorge Ben	layered percussion, lively syncopation, communal energy
Afrobeat	Fela Kuti, Tony Allen	long interlocking grooves, horns, political urgency
Highlife	E.T. Mensah, Osibisa	bright guitars, horns, buoyant dance rhythm
Reggae	Bob Marley, Toots and the Maytals	offbeat guitar, deep bass, spacious drums
Dub	King Tubby, Lee Perry	echo, spring reverb, bass emphasis, studio-as-instrument
Ska	The Skatalites, The Specials	upstroke guitar, horns, quick dance pulse
Folk	Joan Baez, Pete Seeger	acoustic storytelling, simple arrangements, communal melody
Indie folk	Bon Iver, Fleet Foxes	layered harmony, intimate acoustic texture
Americana	Gillian Welch, Jason Isbell	roots instrumentation, narrative songwriting
Bluegrass	Bill Monroe, Alison Krauss	fast acoustic picking, banjo, close harmony
Outlaw country	Willie Nelson, Waylon Jennings	plainspoken vocals, relaxed groove, electric twang
Honky-tonk	Hank Williams, Dwight Yoakam	two-step rhythm, pedal steel, barroom piano
Country pop	Shania Twain, Kacey Musgraves	country timbres with polished pop hooks
Flamenco	Paco de Lucia, Camaron de la Isla	rapid nylon guitar, handclaps, intense vocal ornament
Tango	Astor Piazzolla, Carlos Gardel	bandoneon, sharp accents, dramatic minor harmony
Klezmer	The Klezmatics, Giora Feidman	clarinet ornament, dance rhythm, expressive bends
Raga	Ravi Shankar, Ali Akbar Khan	drone, modal development, long improvisational arc
Gamelan	traditional Balinese ensembles	interlocking metallophones, cyclical rhythm, shimmering texture
Minimalism	Steve Reich, Philip Glass	repetition, phase-like development, gradual process
Neoclassical	Max Richter, Olafur Arnalds	piano and strings, cinematic restraint, modern ambience
Film score	John Williams, Hans Zimmer	leitmotifs, orchestral development, scene-sized dynamics

4. Instrumentation and texture

Instrument prompts work best when they specify role, articulation, register, and processing. 'Guitar' is broad. 'Palm-muted baritone guitar playing syncopated low riffs' is actionable.

Guitars, bass, and plucked strings

Instrument	Core character	Useful modifiers
Nylon-string guitar	warm, rounded, intimate	fingerstyle arpeggios; dry close mic
Steel-string acoustic	bright, percussive, open	strummed eighth notes; picked folk pattern
Clean electric guitar	clear, spacious, articulate	interlocking arpeggios; chorus-treated chords
Overdriven electric	midrange grit and urgency	crunch rhythm; singing lead
Fuzz guitar	thick, unstable, saturated	sustained wall; octave fuzz riff
Baritone guitar	low, dark, muscular	syncopated low riff; tremolo-picked drone
Twelve-string guitar	shimmering and wide	jangling arpeggios; ringing chorus texture
Slide guitar	fluid, vocal-like bends	blues slide answers; ambient swells
Pedal steel	gliding, bittersweet, spacious	country countermelody; sustained bends
Mandolin	bright, quick, woody	tremolo picking; bluegrass chop
Banjo	sharp, rhythmic, rustic	three-finger roll; clawhammer pulse
Harp	luminous, delicate, cascading	glissando transitions; sparse harmonics
Electric bass	focused low-end foundation	melodic counterline; tight eighth-note pulse
Fretless bass	fluid, singing, expressive	sliding jazz melody; sustained upper-register line
Upright bass	woody, acoustic, resonant	walking bass; bowed drone
Synth bass	controlled, deep, shapeable	sub pulse; resonant sequence; rubbery funk line
808 bass	sub-heavy, percussive, modern	gliding notes; long decays; distorted attack

Keyboards and synthesizers

Instrument	Core character	Useful modifiers
Grand piano	wide dynamics, natural resonance	percussive octaves; intimate felt-like touch
Upright piano	compact, woody, imperfect	honky-tonk attack; muted room sound
Felt piano	soft, mechanical, intimate	close-mic minimal motif; audible key noise
Rhodes electric piano	warm, bell-like, soulful	tremolo chords; jazzy extensions
Wurlitzer electric piano	barky, midrange, rhythmic	overdriven chords; funk comping
Hammond organ	swirling, gospel or rock weight	Leslie rotation; sustained chord swells
Pipe organ	massive, sacred, architectural	low pedal tones; cathedral resonance
Harpsichord	bright, plucked, formal	baroque ostinato; dry counterpoint
Clavinet	short, nasal, funky	syncopated sixteenth-note pattern
Analog polysynth	warm, unstable, lush	slow pad; detuned brass stab
Monosynth lead	focused, expressive, synthetic	portamento melody; resonant solo
FM synth	glassy, metallic, precise	bell tone; digital electric piano
Wavetable synth	evolving, modern, detailed	morphing pad; animated bass

Instrument	Core character	Useful modifiers
Modular synth	unpredictable, organic electronic	generative sequence; self-modulating texture
Mellotron	grainy, haunted orchestral color	choir pad; vintage string layer
Vocoder	robotic harmonic speech	chordal backing voice; synthetic lead phrase

Drums and percussion

Instrument	Core character	Useful modifiers
Acoustic drum kit	human impact and room energy	dry close-mic; roomy live kit; loose pocket
Brush kit	soft, textured, jazz-adjacent	brushed snare circles; restrained kick
Electronic kit	precise, synthetic, programmable	tight transients; gated snare; punchy kick
Drum machine	repetitive and era-specific	808 kit; 909 club kit; Linn-style snap
Breakbeat	sampled rhythmic momentum	chopped amen-style break; dusty loop
Double-kick drums	continuous metal propulsion	rapid accents; tightly gated low end
Blast beat	extreme speed and density	short violent burst; sustained black-metal drive
Toms	tribal, cinematic, physical	floor-tom march; stereo tom fill
Timpani	orchestral weight and tension	rolling crescendo; low dramatic hits
Taiko	large cinematic impact	ensemble strikes; accelerating ritual pulse
Congas	warm hand percussion	syncopated open tones; salsa pattern
Bongos	small, sharp hand percussion	busy high-register pattern
Tabla	pitched, intricate hand rhythm	fast ornamented cycle; conversational solo
Cajon	dry acoustic backbeat	brush-like taps; deep center hits
Claps	bright communal accent	layered handclaps; tight disco backbeat
Shaker	continuous high-frequency motion	sixteenth-note drive; loose human feel
Tambourine	bright lift and chorus energy	backbeat accents; accelerating shake
Cowbell	dry, cutting rhythmic marker	sparse syncopation; disco pulse
Found percussion	industrial or tactile character	metal hits; glass taps; wooden knocks

Orchestral, winds, and unusual colors

Instrument	Core character	Useful modifiers
Solo violin	agile, emotional, penetrating	fragile harmonics; dramatic legato
String quartet	intimate counterpoint and tension	pizzicato pulse; dissonant clusters
String orchestra	cinematic width and emotional scale	rising ostinato; sweeping legato
Cello	dark warmth and lyrical depth	bowed melody; percussive spiccato
Contrabass section	low orchestral gravity	tremolo suspense; sustained pedal
Trumpet	bright authority or jazz lyricism	muted solo; mariachi fanfare
Trombone	weight, slides, comic or ominous color	brass stab; growling low line
French horn	heroic warmth and cinematic breadth	noble theme; soft harmonic bed
Saxophone	vocal-like, flexible, sensual or aggressive	breathy tenor solo; baritone riff
Clarinet	woody agility and expressive bends	klezmer ornament; dark chalumeau register
Bass clarinet	hollow low woodwind color	staccato pulse; breathy drone

Instrument	Core character	Useful modifiers
Flute	airy brightness and agility	flutter tongue; pastoral melody
Oboe	nasal, plaintive focus	lonely lyrical theme
Bassoon	reedy low warmth, comic or grave	staccato counterline
Accordion	breathing folk texture	musette waltz; sustained drone
Bandoneon	dark, sharp tango expression	dramatic accented chords
Kalimba	small metallic plucks	gentle ostinato; bright cyclical pattern
Marimba	warm wooden mallet resonance	minimalist pattern; rolling chords
Vibraphone	cool metallic sustain	motor tremolo; jazz chords
Glockenspiel	bright bell sparkle	simple high melody; chorus accents
Theremin	unearthly continuous pitch	haunted glissando melody
Sitar	buzzing resonance and modal character	raga-like lead over drone
Erhu	piercing bowed expression	ornamented lament
Bagpipes	continuous drone and ceremonial intensity	marching melody; massed pipes
Choir	human scale and harmonic grandeur	wordless mixed choir; low male chant
Field recording	specific place and realism	rain, train platform, crowd murmur, machine room

High-value pattern: [instrument] + [role] + [articulation] + [processing]. Example: 'baritone guitar, foreground rhythm role, palm-muted syncopation, dry overdrive.'

5. Vocal design

Vocal prompts become more reliable when they separate voice identity from performance. Identity includes range, weight, texture, age impression, and ensemble. Performance includes intensity, articulation, phrasing, ornament, and microphone distance. Custom mode also provides an explicit Vocal Gender control, while the Style field can add terms such as gritty or soft.[6]

Range and weight

Descriptor	Meaning	Likely effect
Soprano	high, bright, agile	ethereal lead; operatic projection
Mezzo-soprano	warm middle range	theatrical belt; rounded pop lead
Contralto	low, dark female range	smoky intimate delivery
Tenor	high male range	clear melodic lead; soaring chorus
Baritone	medium-low male range	warm authority; theatrical narration
Bass	very low male range	resonant chant; ominous spoken line
Light voice	quick, airy, less weight	delicate indie lead
Full-bodied voice	dense harmonics and power	large soul or rock chorus
Androgynous voice	ambiguous gender cues	art-pop neutrality and flexibility
Youthful voice	bright and direct	energetic pop or punk phrasing
Mature voice	settled, textured, authoritative	storytelling and emotional gravity

Texture and tone

Descriptor	Meaning	Likely effect
Breathy	audible air and intimacy	soft attacks, close emotional distance
Airy	light high-frequency presence	floating dream-pop character
Smoky	dark and slightly rough	late-night jazz or soul atmosphere
Husky	low roughness with warmth	earthy and conversational
Raspy	audible vocal grit	rock intensity and lived-in character
Gravelly	deep coarse texture	blues, country, or heavy rock weight
Clean	minimal grit or distortion	pop clarity and precise pitch impression
Silvery	bright, smooth upper harmonics	ethereal or pristine character
Nasal	forward midrange resonance	punk, folk, or characterful pop edge
Reedy	thin, focused resonance	art-rock or folk distinctiveness
Velvety	smooth and dark	luxurious soul delivery
Whispered	very low intensity and close breath	secrecy, fragility, menace
Shouted	pitched or semi-pitched force	punk urgency and group energy
Screamed	extreme distortion and intensity	metal or post-hardcore climax
Growled	low distorted extreme vocal	death-metal aggression
Fry vocal	creaky low-register texture	intimacy, tension, contemporary pop detail

Delivery and technique

Technique	Meaning	Likely effect
Croon	soft sustained phrasing	intimate traditional pop or lounge feel
Belt	high chest-dominant power	large chorus and emotional peak
Falsetto	light upper register	fragility, lift, or dramatic contrast
Head voice	connected upper register	clearer and fuller than falsetto
Melisma	many pitches on one syllable	R&B, gospel, and virtuosic expression
Vocal run	fast ornamental pitch sequence	improvised flourish
Straight tone	minimal vibrato	modern, austere, choral clarity
Wide vibrato	large regular pitch variation	operatic or theatrical drama
Spoken word	speech over music	narrative focus and rhythmic freedom
Sprechgesang	between speaking and singing	cabaret, expressionism, art-rock tension
Rap	rhythmic speech with defined flow	lyric density and percussive phrasing
Half-sung rap	melodic speech	modern hip-hop and pop flexibility
Scat singing	improvised nonsense syllables	jazz spontaneity
Call and response	lead phrase answered by group	gospel, funk, communal energy
Gang vocals	multiple voices in unison	punk or anthem scale
Close harmony	voices on neighboring chord tones	folk, jazz, or vintage pop richness
Counter melody vocal	secondary independent melody	polyphonic complexity
Wordless vocalise	vowels without lexical lyrics	cinematic or dreamlike atmosphere
Chant	repeated narrow-range phrase	ritual, crowd, or hypnotic momentum
Vocal percussion	mouth-created rhythmic sounds	a cappella or experimental groove

Vocal production

Treatment	Meaning	Likely effect
Close-mic vocal	little room and high intimacy	voice feels near the listener
Distant vocal	more room and less direct sound	dreamlike or isolated perspective
Dry vocal	little audible reverb	direct, modern, confrontational
Plate reverb vocal	smooth bright artificial space	classic polished lead vocal
Cathedral reverb	very long large-space decay	sacred or cinematic scale
Slapback echo	single short echo	1950s rock, country, vintage character
Telephone filter	restricted lows and highs	radio, intercom, memory, transition
Megaphone vocal	nasal distortion and compression	protest, carnival, punk theater
Double-tracked vocal	two near-identical takes	thicker and wider lead
Layered octave vocal	same melody across octaves	dramatic size and gender blend
Hard-tuned vocal	audible pitch correction	synthetic modern pop or trap color
Vocoder harmony	speech-shaped synth chords	robotic ensemble
Formant-shifted vocal	changed apparent vocal size	alien, childlike, monstrous
Granular vocal	voice cut into microscopic grains	glitch texture and abstraction
Reverse-reverb vocal	swell before each phrase	supernatural anticipation
Stereo whisper layers	whispers spread left and right	immersive unease

Treatment	Meaning	Likely effect
Saturated vocal	harmonic distortion and compression	dense rock presence
Lo-fi radio vocal	band-limited, noisy, compressed	historical broadcast or found recording

For a 1920s broadcaster or carnival-host effect: 'nasal midrange baritone, exaggerated theatrical diction, fast patter, lo-fi AM radio filter, shellac crackle, narrow bandwidth, light megaphone distortion.'

6. Rhythm, tempo, and meter

Tempo gives speed. Groove describes placement and feel. Meter describes the recurring beat framework. A 100 BPM shuffle, straight rock beat, and halftime trap groove can feel radically different despite sharing a tempo.

Tempo vocabulary

Term	Approximation	Effect
Largo	40-60 BPM	very slow, broad, ceremonial
Adagio	66-76 BPM	slow and expressive
Andante	76-108 BPM	walking pace and moderate motion
Moderato	roughly 108-120 BPM	controlled forward movement
Allegro	120-168 BPM	fast and lively
Presto	168-200 BPM	very fast and urgent
Half-time feel	same BPM, slower perceived pulse	heavy spacious backbeat
Double-time feel	same BPM, faster subdivisions	heightened urgency
Rubato	flexible local tempo	expressive acceleration and delay
Accelerando	gradual speeding up	mounting excitement or instability
Ritardando	gradual slowing down	closure, collapse, or anticipation

Groove and rhythmic behavior

Term	Definition	Effect
Straight	even subdivision	precise rock, pop, or electronic motion
Swung	unequal subdivision	bounce and jazz-derived movement
Shuffle	triplet-based long-short pattern	blues and rock locomotion
Syncopated	accents away from expected beats	tension and dance energy
Behind the beat	attacks slightly late	relaxed, heavy, soulful pocket
Ahead of the beat	attacks slightly early	nervous or urgent drive
Four-on-the-floor	kick on every quarter note	disco, house, steady dance energy
Breakbeat	syncopated sampled-drum logic	hip-hop, jungle, electronic propulsion
Motorik	steady kick and forward repetition	hypnotic krautrock movement
Clave-based	organized around recurring clave pattern	Afro-Cuban structural pulse
Tresillo	3+3+2 accent grouping	Latin, pop, and global rhythmic lift
Gallop	long-short-short repeated figure	metal and cinematic charging motion
Stop-start	bursts separated by rests	math rock, funk, comic surprise
Polyrhythm	different rhythms at once	layered tension and complexity
Hemiola	temporary 3-against-2 reinterpretation	metric ambiguity and lift

Meters and phrasing

Meter term	Meaning	Effect
4/4	four quarter-note beats	default pop, rock, dance stability

Meter term	Meaning	Effect
3/4	three quarter-note beats	waltz motion and circular phrasing
6/8	two large beats divided into three	rolling ballad or compound drive
12/8	four large beats divided into three	blues, gospel, slow-rock breadth
5/4	uneven five-beat cycle	lopsided but spacious sophistication
7/8	often grouped 2+2+3 or 3+2+2	restless forward motion
9/8	compound or asymmetrical nine	folk dance, prog complexity, rolling motion
11/8	asymmetrical long cycle	progressive tension and surprise
Mixed meter	meter changes between passages	narrative and progressive instability
Additive rhythm	beats grouped in unequal cells	Balkan, prog, or contemporary classical feel
Free time	no obvious recurring pulse	ambient, recitative, ritual opening
Metric modulation	subdivision becomes a new pulse	smooth but dramatic tempo transformation
Odd-length phrase	phrase crosses normal bar boundaries	unsettled hooks and delayed resolution

For meter changes, describe both the meter and the musical event: 'tense 7/8 guitar verse, broader 5/4 pre-chorus, release into a straight 4/4 chorus.' Raw notation alone may be sung, skipped, or ignored.

7. Harmony and melody

Harmony terms are less consistently obeyed than broad genre or instrumentation, but they can meaningfully bias color and motion. Use a few compatible harmonic descriptors instead of writing a complete theoretical specification.

Harmony vocabulary

Term	Meaning	Likely effect
Major key	bright tonal center	confidence, openness, celebration
Natural minor	dark stable minor color	melancholy, seriousness
Harmonic minor	raised leading tone in minor	dramatic, classical, exoticized tension
Dorian mode	minor with raised sixth	hopeful minor, jazz-funk motion
Phrygian mode	minor with lowered second	dark flamenco or metal tension
Lydian mode	major with raised fourth	wonder, suspension, cinematic brightness
Mixolydian mode	major with lowered seventh	rock, folk, blues openness
Pentatonic melody	five-note scale logic	direct memorable melody
Blues scale	minor pentatonic plus blue note	grit, expressive bends
Chromatic harmony	notes outside a single key	instability and sophistication
Modal harmony	long focus on a mode or pedal	open, hypnotic development
Quartal harmony	chords built from fourths	modern jazz and spacious ambiguity
Extended jazz chords	sevenths, ninths, elevenths	lush sophisticated color
Power chords	root and fifth, no third	harmonic ambiguity and guitar weight
Drone harmony	sustained reference pitch	ritual, folk, ambient stability
Pedal point	fixed bass note under changes	tension and continuity
Ostinato	repeated melodic or rhythmic cell	hypnosis and structural glue
Counterpoint	independent simultaneous melodies	complexity and conversational texture
Dissonance	clashing intervals	tension, abrasion, unease
Suspension	held note resolving downward	controlled yearning
Deceptive cadence	expected ending diverted	surprise and continued motion
Plagal cadence	IV to I motion	hymnal or reflective closure
Key change	new tonal center	renewed energy or final-chorus lift
Chromatic mediants	roots related by thirds outside key	cinematic surprise
Descending bass line	bass steps downward beneath chords	lament, inevitability
Circle-of-fifths motion	roots move by fifths	strong harmonic direction
Unresolved harmony	avoid final tonic closure	ambiguity and open ending

Melodic direction

Term	Meaning	Likely effect
Stepwise melody	mostly neighboring pitches	singable and flowing
Angular melody	large or unexpected intervals	art-rock tension and distinctiveness

Term	Meaning	Likely effect
Narrow-range melody	few pitches	chant, intimacy, rhythmic focus
Wide-range melody	large pitch span	drama and vocal athleticism
Motivic development	small idea transformed repeatedly	cohesion with evolution
Call-and-response melody	phrase answered by another	conversation and communal energy
Sequence	motif repeated at new pitch levels	rising momentum
Arpeggiated melody	chord tones unfolded	clarity and harmonic emphasis
Melodic hook	short memorable phrase	pop recognition
Through-composed melody	little exact repetition	narrative continuity
Descending lament	falling repeated contour	grief and inevitability
Ascending anthem	rising contour into held note	triumph and release

8. Structure and arrangement

Suno recognizes conventional structural language, and its official glossary includes verse, chorus, bridge, pre-chorus, intro, outro, hook, refrain, break, and drop.[2] Square-bracket labels are widely used as lyric-field cues. Treat elaborate bracket instructions as suggestions, because the model may sing or ignore unfamiliar text.

Reliable section labels

Label	Function	Prompting expectation
[Intro]	establish tone before the narrative	instrumental motif, atmosphere, or vocal pickup
[Verse]	deliver changing narrative material	lower density and restrained melody
[Pre-Chorus]	increase expectation before chorus	rising harmony, drums, or vocal range
[Chorus]	state the repeated central hook	largest melody and clearest repetition
[Post-Chorus]	extend hook after chorus	chant, riff, or instrumental response
[Refrain]	repeat a line within or after verses	smaller recurring anchor than full chorus
[Bridge]	introduce contrast late in the song	new harmony, perspective, or texture
[Break]	remove or reduce instruments	contrast and reset
[Breakdown]	strip to a heavy or reduced pattern	metal, electronic, or dramatic low point
[Drop]	release accumulated electronic energy	bass and drum impact
[Interlude]	short contrasting passage	instrumental or atmospheric transition
[Instrumental]	foreground instruments without lyrics	solo, motif, or development
[Solo]	feature one instrument	lead guitar, saxophone, synth, drums
[Build]	gradually add intensity	risers, density, crescendo
[Climax]	maximum musical and emotional intensity	full ensemble and highest vocal energy
[Outro]	close after final main section	fade, repeated hook, or new ending material
[Coda]	distinct concluding passage	composed resolution beyond the main form

Arrangement modifiers

Term	Meaning	Likely effect
Sparse	few simultaneous parts	clarity, intimacy, negative space
Dense	many simultaneous layers	maximal energy and harmonic mass
Gradual build	elements accumulate over time	controlled anticipation
Loud-soft dynamics	sharp contrast between sections	alternative rock and dramatic release
Through-composed	new material continues without chorus repetition	narrative or progressive form
Strophic	same music for each verse	folk simplicity and lyric emphasis
Theme and variations	one idea repeatedly transformed	cohesion with exploration
Rondo	main theme returns between contrasts	recognizable anchor in extended form
Suite-like	several connected movements	large-scale progressive development
False ending	apparent stop followed by return	surprise and theatricality
Final chorus lift	larger final return	extra harmony, octave doubling, or key change

Term	Meaning	Likely effect
Instrumental coda	vocals end before music	space for thematic resolution
Hard stop	all parts end together	decisive conclusion
Long fade	repetition gradually disappears	continuation beyond the recording
Unresolved sustain	final chord avoids clear resolution	ambiguity and afterimage

Lyric architecture example

[Intro - instrumental, distant radio voice]

[Verse 1 - restrained]

The sunlight gathers on the wire
A yellow theorem catches fire

[Pre-Chorus - rising harmony]

Count the missing beat
Feel the pattern lean

[Chorus - full band]

Lemon yellow, open the sky
Seven steps forward, four passing by

[Bridge - whispered equations over bass drone]

No north, no ending, no absolute line

[Final Chorus - layered vocals, wider arrangement]

Lemon yellow, open the sky

[Outro - guitar feedback, hard stop]

9. Production, mix, and effects

Production language describes the recording as much as the composition. Use terms that imply an audible change. The official glossary explicitly lists reverb, delay, compression, distortion, filters, modulation, panning, EQ, sampling, loops, and fades.[2]

Space, delay, and modulation

Term	What it does	Audible effect
Room reverb	short natural reflection	small realistic performance space
Hall reverb	longer smooth reflection	concert scale and depth
Cathedral reverb	very long dramatic decay	sacred, monumental space
Plate reverb	bright smooth artificial tail	polished vocal or snare presence
Spring reverb	metallic bouncing decay	surf guitar, dub, vintage hardware
Convolution reverb	captured real-space character	specific architectural realism
Gated reverb	reverb cut off abruptly	large 1980s drums without long tail
Reverse reverb	effect swells before source	supernatural anticipation
Slapback delay	single short repeat	rockabilly, country, vintage vocal
Tape echo	warm degrading repeats	psychedelic and dub movement
Ping-pong delay	repeats alternate stereo sides	wide rhythmic motion
Dotted-eighth delay	syncopated repeating echo	propulsive ambient guitar
Chorus effect	slightly detuned duplicates	wide shimmer
Flanger	moving comb-filter sweep	metallic jet-like motion
Phaser	smooth phase cancellation sweep	psychedelic swirl
Rotary speaker	spinning amplitude and pitch motion	organ movement and vintage depth
Tremolo	repeated volume change	pulsing guitar or keyboard
Vibrato	repeated pitch change	wobble and expressive instability
Auto-pan	automatic stereo movement	motion across the soundstage

Distortion, degradation, and digital processing

Term	What it does	Audible effect
Overdrive	soft amplifier clipping	warm grit and harmonic density
Distortion	stronger clipping	aggressive edge and sustain
Fuzz	extreme square-like clipping	thick unstable wall of harmonics
Tube saturation	gentle nonlinear warmth	rounded transients and rich mids
Tape saturation	magnetic compression and harmonics	warm cohesive vintage finish
Console saturation	subtle desk-like coloration	density and glue
Bitcrushing	reduced digital resolution	grainy game-like harshness
Sample-rate reduction	reduced temporal resolution	aliasing and brittle digital texture
Wavefolding	signal folds beyond threshold	complex bright synth distortion
Ring modulation	multiplies signals	metallic inharmonic tones

Term	What it does	Audible effect
Granular synthesis	sound divided into tiny grains	clouds, freezes, fragmentation
Spectral processing	manipulates frequency components	smears, morphs, ghostly detail
Stutter edit	rapid repeated fragments	glitch rhythm and interruption
Tape stop	playback rapidly slows	dramatic pitch-down transition
Vinyl crackle	record surface noise	nostalgia and lo-fi framing
Wow and flutter	slow and fast pitch instability	worn tape or turntable character
Dropout	brief signal loss	damaged-media texture
Feedback	output recirculates into input	sustained tone, danger, guitar bloom
Noise gate	silences signal below threshold	tight stops or unnatural chopping

Dynamics, tone, stereo, and mix language

Term	What it does	Audible effect
Compression	reduces level differences	consistent loudness and added density
Parallel compression	blends compressed and dry signals	impact while keeping transients
Sidechain compression	one signal ducks another	pumping around kick or vocal
Limiter	prevents peaks above ceiling	loudness and peak control
Transient shaping	changes attack and sustain	punchier or softer drums
De-essing	reduces harsh sibilance	smoother vocal consonants
High-pass filter	removes low frequencies	thinness, clarity, telephone transitions
Low-pass filter	removes high frequencies	muffling, distance, underwater effect
Band-pass filter	keeps a middle band	radio or telephone sound
Resonant filter	emphasizes cutoff region	squelch and electronic motion
Warm low mids	emphasizes body region	fullness and intimacy
Open low mids	avoids muddy buildup	clearer instrument separation
High-end air	gentle extreme-high lift	clarity and expensive sheen
Dark mix	reduced brightness	weight, age, mystery
Bright mix	strong high-frequency presence	clarity, excitement, possible harshness
Wide stereo image	parts spread left and right	scale and immersion
Narrow mono image	limited stereo width	vintage focus and intimacy
Center-focused vocal	lead remains stable in middle	clarity and authority
Hard-panned guitars	guitars separated left and right	wide rock arrangement
Front-to-back depth	different apparent distances	three-dimensional mix
Dry close-mic drums	little room ambience	tight modern punch
Roomy live drums	audible performance room	organic scale and energy
Crisp transients	clear initial attacks	definition and rhythmic precision
Soft transients	rounded attacks	dreamy or vintage smoothness
Clear instrument separation	less masking between parts	readable dense arrangement
Glue	elements feel unified	cohesive bus-compressed impression

Term	What it does	Audible effect
Dynamic master	retains loud-soft contrast	breathing, less crushed presentation
Loud modern master	high average level	immediate impact, reduced dynamic range

Production eras as shorthand

Era shorthand	Typical signals	Result
1950s mono	narrow bandwidth, room bleed, slapback	small ensemble immediacy
1960s psychedelic	tape effects, hard pans, spring reverb	colorful experimental vintage
1970s analog	warm tape, live room, moderate separation	organic band depth
1980s polished	gated drums, bright synths, chorus	large glossy drama
1990s alternative	guitars forward, comparatively dry vocals	physical band sound
1990s trip-hop	dusty breaks, deep bass, dark samples	cinematic nocturnal mood
2000s loud rock	dense guitars, compressed drums, bright vocals	aggressive radio impact
Modern pop	tight low end, layered vocals, bright transients	clean controlled finish
Lo-fi bedroom	noise, narrow range, small room	private handmade character
Audiophile live-room	natural dynamics and spatial realism	performers sharing a space

10. Lyrics, diction, and symbolic text

Custom mode accepts original lyrics, and the writer retains rights to those original words.[5] The lyric field is also where section labels are commonly placed. Keep instructions visibly separate from singable text.

Formatting principles

- Use one lyric phrase per line. Line breaks suggest breaths and melodic units.
- Keep verses in consistent blocks. Put a blank line between sections.
- Repeat the chorus text when exact recurrence matters.
- Use parentheses for likely backing responses, but expect occasional lead-vocal treatment.
- Use hyphens or separated syllables only when you want fragmentation or prolonged diction.
- Spell unusual names phonetically when pronunciation matters.
- Avoid placing prose production notes outside brackets because Suno may sing them.

Punctuation tendencies

Device	Likely interpretation	Advice
Comma	small internal pause	use for phrasing, not precise timing
Period	stronger phrase boundary	may create a cadence or breath
Ellipsis	hesitation or extended pause	can also cause awkward diction
Question mark	rising or questioning delivery	not guaranteed
Exclamation mark	greater intensity	often weaker than explicit vocal direction
Parentheses	backing vocal or aside association	may still be sung by the lead
Repeated letters	extended vowel or stylized pronunciation	can become unpredictable
Hyphenated syllables	fragmented or spelled delivery	use sparingly
Capital letters	visual emphasis	not a reliable loudness control
Blank line	section or phrase separation	often more useful than decorative spacing

Phonetic writing

Problem	Technique	Example
Name is mispronounced	rewrite by sound	Merced -> Mer Said when that matches the target pronunciation
Acronym becomes a word	separate letters	A D B C rather than ADBC
Letters run together	add commas or periods	A, D, B, C or A. D. B. C.
Number is ambiguous	write the intended spoken form	seven eighths rather than 7/8
URL sounds awkward	write a spoken form	example dot com
Foreign word is unstable	approximate target-language syllables	test several spellings
Long technical phrase is rushed	split across short lines	one conceptual unit per line

Symbols, equations, emoji, and visual poetry

Unicode symbols are not a dependable notation system. Equations may be partially verbalized, skipped, or converted into vocal artifacts. Emoji may be ignored or weakly associated with mood. Decorative spacing may collapse. ASCII art is not interpreted as a picture.

Input	Risk	Safer alternative
7/8 -> 5/4 -> 4/4	numbers may be sung	put meter changes in Style and section labels
E = mc2	partial or awkward pronunciation	write 'E equals M C squared'
BASS DECAY	instruction may be sung	use [Bass decays into silence]
I e m o n	letters may be spelled or stretched	use intentionally for fragmented diction
emoji rows	often ignored or token noise	write the intended mood or sound
ASCII diagrams	no visual understanding	convert the image into an audible direction
mathematical operators	unpredictable tokenization	spell out only what should be heard

Experimental version: keep a few equations as intentional vocal uncertainty, but repeat critical musical controls in plain language. This preserves the visual-poetry effect without depending on symbols to steer meter or production.

11. Artist references translated into traits

Suno states that generations may be blocked when prompts include names of well-known artists or people.[19] Use artist names for private listening analysis, then translate them into genre, era, arrangement, vocal, and production traits. Do not request imitation of a living performer or reuse protected lyrics.

Rock, pop, and experimental mappings

Reference	Prompt-safe musical translation
David Bowie	theatrical art rock, shape-shifting arrangement, expressive baritone, glam-era drama, surreal narrative
Queen	operatic rock, stacked choir harmonies, piano and guitar grandeur, abrupt theatrical contrasts
Talking Heads	angular new wave, nervous funk groove, clipped guitar, conversational art-rock vocal
Earth Wind and Fire	horn-driven funk and disco, agile bass, polished vocal harmonies, joyful rhythmic precision
Bjork	experimental art pop, intimate-to-explosive vocals, unusual electronic percussion, strings, organic digital texture
The Mars Volta	frenetic progressive post-hardcore, Latin percussion, irregular meter, high dramatic vocals, extended transitions
The Blood Brothers	chaotic post-hardcore, shrill dual vocals, stop-start riffs, compressed intensity
Radiohead	art rock, ambiguous harmony, restrained vocal vulnerability, electronic texture, dramatic negative space
Kate Bush	literary art pop, theatrical high female vocal, eccentric orchestration, narrative movement
Prince	minimal funk, sharp drum-machine groove, falsetto, guitar virtuosity, sensual vocal layering
Peter Gabriel	world-influenced art rock, deep theatrical voice, layered percussion, cinematic production
Tame Impala	psychedelic pop, compressed drums, phaser-heavy guitars, hazy vocals, warm synth bass
The Flaming Lips	neo-psychedelic pop, fragile vocals, distorted color, childlike wonder, large emotional choruses
Steely Dan	jazz-rock harmony, dry witty delivery, meticulous studio arrangement, clean guitar and keyboard detail
Sade	sophisti-pop and quiet storm, restrained contralto, spacious groove, elegant clean production
Cocteau Twins	dream pop, glossolalia-like soprano, chorus guitars, luminous reverb, blurred diction
My Bloody Valentine	shoegaze, pitch-bending guitar layers, buried soft vocals, dense stereo haze
Nine Inch Nails	industrial rock, mechanical percussion, distorted synths, intimate-to-screamed male vocal, abrasive dynamics
Devo	quirky new wave, stiff robotic groove, nasal vocals, short synth hooks, satirical tension
Frank Zappa	satirical avant-prog, rapid style changes, virtuosic ensemble, odd meter, spoken interruptions

Heavy, punk, electronic, and hip-hop mappings

Reference	Prompt-safe musical translation
Tool	progressive metal, polymetric drums, hypnotic bass, restrained verses, long heavy crescendos
Meshuggah	mechanical low-tuned metal, polymetric riffs, harsh vocals, precise kick patterns
Nirvana	raw grunge trio, quiet verses, explosive distorted choruses, cracked melodic vocal
Soundgarden	heavy alternative rock, odd meters, wide-range powerful male vocal, dark riff harmony
My Chemical Romance	theatrical emo rock, urgent tenor, narrative concept-song energy, massed final chorus
Panic at the Disco early era	baroque-tinged pop rock, cabaret drama, quick lyrical phrasing, abrupt arrangement changes
Fugazi	dry post-hardcore, interlocking guitars, disciplined rhythm section, shouted ethical urgency

Reference	Prompt-safe musical translation
Massive Attack	dark trip-hop, slow breakbeats, deep sub-bass, cinematic samples, alternating intimate voices
Portishead	noir trip-hop, dusty drums, fragile female vocal, minor-key strings, vinyl-worn atmosphere
Aphex Twin	IDM, intricate programmed drums, uncanny synth timbres, playful harmonic unease
Autechre	abstract electronic rhythm, algorithmic-feeling percussion, metallic synthesis, unstable form
Daft Punk	filter disco, vocoder hooks, compressed dance groove, bright repeated synth figures
The Prodigy	breakbeat rave, distorted synth bass, punk vocal energy, aggressive drum loops
Burial	future garage, shuffled drums, ghostly vocal fragments, rain-like ambience, deep nocturnal bass
J Dilla	loose sampled hip-hop, deliberately off-grid drums, warm bass, chopped soul texture
OutKast	inventive Southern hip-hop, elastic flow, funk instrumentation, playful structural changes
Kendrick Lamar	narrative hip-hop, multiple vocal characters, jazz-funk color, dramatic perspective shifts
Run-D.M.C.	minimal old-school rap, hard drum machine, shouted trade-off vocals, sparse riffs

Artist translation worksheet

Dimension	Question	Example answer
Genre	What two genre families dominate?	theatrical art rock and progressive pop
Era	Which production period is audible?	late-1970s analog studio sound
Rhythm	What makes the groove distinctive?	piano-led 6/8 with sudden straight 4/4 release
Harmony	What is the harmonic color?	chromatic minor verses and bright major chorus
Instruments	Which three sounds identify it?	grand piano, layered electric guitar, massed choir
Voice	What are range, texture, and delivery?	expressive baritone, conversational verses, soaring belt
Arrangement	How does energy move?	small opening, accelerating middle, operatic final climax
Production	How close, wide, bright, or distorted?	close vocal, wide guitars, warm tape saturation

12. Hybrid genres and controlled contrast

A useful hybrid gives each influence a job. 'Progressive rock plus grunge' is vague. 'Progressive-rock meter and development with grunge guitar tone and raw vocal delivery' defines the contribution of both styles.

Hybrid design patterns

Pattern	Method	Example
Foundation plus color	one genre controls structure, another controls timbre	prog-rock form with grunge guitar texture
Verse versus chorus	styles occupy separate sections	trip-hop verse into post-hardcore chorus
Acoustic versus electronic	instrument families provide contrast	folk melody over glitch percussion
Historical collision	one era's writing with another era's production	1960s soul song with modern sub-bass and vocal editing
Rhythm transplant	borrow a groove without borrowing the whole genre	art pop over a motorik beat
Vocal transplant	place one delivery inside another arrangement	crooning baritone over industrial techno
Production transplant	keep composition, change recording language	bluegrass ensemble with shoegaze reverb
Progressive transformation	song gradually becomes another genre	chamber pop evolving into doom metal
Alternating worlds	two styles return in a stable pattern	cabaret verse alternating with math-rock refrain
Shared trait bridge	choose genres with one common feature	funk and math rock linked by syncopation

Compatibility map

Combination	Strength	Control advice
Prog rock + art pop	theatrical complexity	define which sections repeat
Math rock + glitch	precision and fragmentation	keep the instrument list small
Grunge + prog rock	raw tone with developed form	use one consistent vocalist
Trip-hop + dream pop	slow cinematic atmosphere	protect bass and vocal clarity
Funk + post-punk	angular dance groove	request dry production
Disco + psychedelic pop	bright rhythmic surrealism	avoid excessive reverb on bass
Industrial + cabaret	mechanical theatricality	assign voice and percussion clearly
Folk + ambient	storytelling in spacious texture	keep lyrics short and sparse
Jazz fusion + metal	virtuosity and weight	specify clean versus distorted passages
Chamber pop + electronic glitch	ornate acoustic-digital contrast	identify foreground motif
Gospel + progressive rock	choir-driven large form	reserve choir for peaks
Dub + post-rock	echo-based instrumental build	ask for controlled low-end space

When a hybrid becomes muddy, remove a genre label and preserve its useful trait. Replace 'funk, prog, grunge, industrial, cabaret' with 'avant-prog structure, syncopated funk bass, raw distorted guitar, theatrical baritone.'

13. Models, sliders, and advanced controls

Current model choices

As of September 2026, Suno describes v6 as its most controlled and precise model, v6-wild as the experimental option, and v6-mini as the faster model available to all users.[1]

Model	Best use	Practical prompting approach
v6	finished work and controlled interpretation	focused prompt, strong style influence, deliberate iteration
v6-wild	unexpected arrangements and experimental discovery	simpler prompt, tolerate reinterpretation, harvest surprises
v6-mini	fast sketches and broad exploration	test concepts cheaply, then rebuild promising directions

Creative sliders

Suno defines Weirdness from Safe to Chaos, with 50 percent as the normal expected result. Style Influence ranges from Loose to Strong. Audio Influence appears with audio uploads.[3]

Control	Lower setting	Higher setting	Working method
Weirdness	conventional choices and safer form	unusual timbres, transitions, or structures	start near normal; raise after identity is stable
Style Influence	more model freedom	closer adherence to Style text	raise when genre or ensemble keeps drifting
Audio Influence	more reinterpretation of upload	closer relationship to source audio	raise when melody, voice, or groove must remain recognizable

Explicit and reusable controls

Feature	What it preserves or changes	Best use
Exclude	discourages named instruments or traits	remove trap hi-hats, choir, reverb wash, or other defaults [4]
Vocal Gender	guides male or female voice selection	use alongside texture and delivery words [6]
Voice	uses a verified personal voice profile	identity continuity; clean a cappella sources work best [7]
Custom Model	learns from at least six owned songs	repeated personal style across new generations [8]
Style Persona	recalls the vocals and style essence of a prior song	continue an established project identity [9]
My Taste	personalizes augmented style suggestions	idea discovery; disable when neutrality is important [10]
Audio Upload	uses recorded material as a starting point	preserve a riff, melody, rhythm, or sonic seed [11]
Cover	changes style while seeking to retain melody	large rearrangement of a song you created [12]
Inspire	draws mood, tempo, and instrumentation from your playlist	project-level cohesion; Suno suggests 3-5 songs for control [13]
Add Vocals	layers generated vocals onto an instrumental	test toplines; describe both instrumental and desired vocal [14]
Extend	continues from a selected point with new lyrics or style	repair endings or grow a promising section [15]
Replace Section	regenerates a selected region	fix one verse, transition, or performance problem [16]
Remaster	refines mix, balance, texture, or pronunciation	polish a successful song without major restructuring [17]

Feature	What it preserves or changes	Best use
Sounds	creates one-shots, loops, ambience, or effects	generate production assets using concise sound vocabulary [18]
Stem Separation	extracts detected or selected components	edit, remix, rebalance, or continue work in a DAW [20]

A/B testing protocol

- Lock lyrics, model, and sliders. Change only the Style prompt.
- Generate at least two candidates per prompt version.
- Score identity, vocal fit, arrangement, diction, mix, and ending separately.
- Keep the winning prompt. Change only one layer in the next round.
- Use Replace Section or Extend when most of the song already works.
- Use Remaster for polish, not for changing the composition.[17]

14. Iteration and troubleshooting

Troubleshooting works when each revision tests a hypothesis. Diagnose the failing layer, alter one or two clauses, and compare multiple outputs.

Symptom	Likely cause	Revision
Genre sounds generic	genre term is too broad	add subgenre, era, groove, and one signature instrument
Prompt feels ignored	too many competing instructions	reduce to one dominant genre and six essential clauses
Wrong singer character	voice described only by gender	add range, texture, delivery, and microphone distance
Chorus lacks lift	no arrangement contrast	request thinner verse, rising pre-chorus, full-band chorus
Song is constantly loud	prompt requests energy without dynamics	specify sparse verse and reserved climax
Mix is muddy	too many dense layers or low-mid instruments	request clear separation, open low mids, fewer foreground parts
Vocals are buried	dense arrangement and long reverb	request center-focused close-mic lead, reduced reverb
Vocals sound synthetic	hard tuning or excessive layers implied	request natural phrasing, minimal tuning, dry intimate performance
Lyrics are rushed	too many syllables per section	shorten lines, add breaks, reduce tempo, split thoughts
Words are mispronounced	orthography is ambiguous	use phonetic spelling and isolate the word on a line
Instructions are sung	plain prose placed in Lyrics	move global directions to Style; bracket only concise cues
Meter change fails	notation lacks musical context	name meter, section, grouping, and destination
Instrument never appears	it is buried in a long list	name it as foreground and assign a role
Unwanted instrument appears	genre convention supplies it	add the instrument or trait to Exclude [4]
Ending is abrupt	model runs out of form or lyric plan	request short coda, fade, or hard stop; use Extend if needed [15]
Song repeats too much	chorus and hooks dominate	request through-composed form or evolving verses
Song wanders	too much freedom or weirdness	increase Style Influence, lower Weirdness, simplify form
Song is predictable	prompt overconstrains choices	raise Weirdness or try v6-wild [1][3]
Uploaded idea disappears	Audio Influence is too low	raise Audio Influence and describe the source role [3][11]
Remaster changes too much	variation strength is too high	use Subtle rather than Normal or High [17]
Artist name is blocked	well-known name triggers moderation	replace it with genre, era, vocal, and production traits [19]
Symbols create gibberish	text tokenizer cannot infer intended reading	spell important content in ordinary language
“Epic” sounds generic	abstract adjective lacks orchestration	name drums, strings, choir, build, and climax
“Vintage” is inconsistent	era is underspecified	name decade, recording format, room, and signature effects

Evaluation scorecard

Dimension	Question	Score
Identity	Does the first 20 seconds establish the intended genre and era?	1-5
Groove	Does the rhythm create the intended physical feeling?	1-5
Voice	Does range, tone, diction, and delivery fit the lyric?	1-5
Arrangement	Do sections contrast and build toward a clear destination?	1-5
Instrumentation	Are the defining instruments audible in their intended roles?	1-5
Lyrics	Are words complete, intelligible, and naturally phrased?	1-5
Production	Are depth, width, brightness, and density appropriate?	1-5
Ending	Does the song conclude intentionally?	1-5
Distinctiveness	Does the result have a memorable musical decision?	1-5

15. Copy-ready prompt recipes

Progressive grunge

Progressive alternative rock with raw grunge guitar tone, 96 BPM, mixed 7/8 and 4/4, low-tuned electric guitar, melodic bass, roomy acoustic drums, weathered baritone moving from intimate restraint to cracked full-voice choruses, long developmental bridge, clear instrument separation, warm tape saturation, final unresolved feedback sustain.

Theatrical art rock

Theatrical art rock and baroque pop, brisk 6/8, grand piano, electric guitar, chamber strings, timpani, expressive baritone, conversational verses and stacked choir refrains, abrupt scene changes, operatic final climax, 1970s analog warmth, wide stereo arrangement, decisive hard stop.

Math-rock glitch

Math rock with glitch electronica, tense 7/8 grouped 2+2+3, interlocking clean guitars, elastic bass, dry live drums, granular synth interruptions, clipped androgynous vocal, stop-start verses, brief instrumental calculations, crisp transients, stutter edits, narrow verses expanding into a wide final chorus.

Noir trip-hop

Noir trip-hop, 76 BPM, dusty breakbeat, deep sub-bass, minor-key Rhodes, muted trumpet fragments, intimate smoky contralto, restrained verse melody, cinematic bridge, vinyl crackle, tape echo, dark wide mix, long instrumental fade.

Industrial cabaret

Industrial cabaret and theatrical post-punk, 118 BPM march, metallic found percussion, distorted synth bass, detuned upright piano, nasal dramatic baritone with megaphone asides, alternating spoken verses and shouted refrains, abrupt machine stops, narrow-band radio intro, saturated mono ending.

Dream-pop lament

Dream pop with chamber-pop detail, slow 72 BPM, chorus-treated guitars, felt piano, cello, soft electronic pulse, airy layered soprano, short breath-separated lines, gradual harmonic bloom, luminous hall reverb, soft transients, final vocals dissolving into ambience.

Funk art rock

Angular art rock over a dry syncopated funk groove, 112 BPM, clipped rhythm guitar, active melodic bass, tight acoustic drums, clavinet, occasional brass stabs, conversational male tenor, restrained verses and explosive call-and-response chorus, minimal reverb, center-focused vocal, hard stop.

Psychedelic synth-pop

Psychedelic synth-pop, 124 BPM, warm analog arpeggiators, compressed live drums, phaser guitar, rubbery synth bass, dreamy high male vocal with double-tracked chorus, colorful harmonic detours, tape echo, saturated 1970s texture with modern low-end control, extended instrumental coda.

Cinematic post-rock

Instrumental post-rock and neoclassical ambience, 68 BPM rising to double-time, delayed clean guitar, piano ostinato, string orchestra, floor toms, low brass, three-stage gradual build, enormous final crescendo, natural room depth, wide dynamics, long decaying final chord.

Hyperpop rupture

Hyperpop and digital hardcore, 155 BPM, distorted synth bass, clipped kick, metallic snare, pitched vocal fragments, bright youthful lead alternating sweetness and shouted overload, micro-sections, sudden silence, bitcrushing, formant shifts, extreme stereo edits, short clean ending after maximal climax.

Lo-fi folk memory

Intimate indie folk, 82 BPM with loose human timing, fingerpicked steel-string guitar, upright bass, brushed snare, distant pump organ, mature close-mic vocal, narrative strophic verses, small harmony refrain, tape hiss, narrow stereo image, audible room, gentle fade.

Afrobeat art pop

Afrobeat-informed art pop, 108 BPM, interlocking clean guitars, layered hand percussion, agile bass, horn responses, expressive contralto, call-and-response chorus, long groove sections with evolving arrangement, dry rhythm section, bright but controlled brass, live-room energy.

Dub post-rock

Dub production applied to post-rock, 78 BPM, deep bass, sparse drums, delayed guitar harmonics, organ swells, almost wordless distant vocal, long negative spaces, spring reverb throws, tape echo feedback, gradual instrumental build, bass remains centered and clear, fade into echoes.

Jazz-metal fusion

Progressive jazz-metal fusion, 132 BPM with mixed meter, seven-string guitar alternating clean quartal chords and tight low riffs, fretless bass, acoustic drums, Rhodes, tenor saxophone, controlled gritty tenor vocal used sparingly, extended instrumental development, precise attacks, dry detailed mix.

1920s radio carnival

Dark carnival cabaret, 126 BPM two-step, detuned upright piano, tuba bass, snare rolls, clarinet flourishes, nasal theatrical baritone with rapid patter, lo-fi 1920s radio filter, shellac crackle, narrow bandwidth, light megaphone distortion, sudden full-band accents, comic false ending.

Lemon Yellow visual poem

Avant-prog, math rock, experimental art pop, and glitch electronica, luminous but uncanny, alternating 7/8 verse, 5/4 bridge, and resolving 4/4 refrain, angular clean guitar, elastic distorted bass, dry polyrhythmic drums, whispered equations, fragmented syllables, granular vocal edits, tape decay, spectral reverb, abrupt silence, final word 'yellow' dissolving into guitar feedback.

Useful Exclude sets

Goal	Exclude text
Organic rock	trap hi-hats, 808 bass, synthetic risers, hard-tuned vocals
Dry intimate recording	cathedral reverb, reverb wash, huge choir, cinematic percussion
No generic climax	key-change final chorus, trailer drums, massed strings
Clean electronic detail	muddy low mids, harsh high end, distorted master, excessive sidechain pumping
Instrumental focus	lead vocals, spoken word, choir, vocal chops
Natural vocal	hard tuning, vocoder, formant shifting, excessive vocal layering
Avoid guitar-rock defaults	power chords, guitar solo, arena drums
Avoid pop defaults	four-on-the-floor beat, bright synth hook, repeated post-chorus chant

16. Master vocabulary index

Use this index as a prompt-building palette. Select one or two terms from each relevant row rather than copying the entire list.

Mood and emotional direction

Family	Vocabulary
Positive	euphoric, radiant, playful, tender, hopeful, triumphant, buoyant, affectionate
Negative	melancholic, desolate, anxious, bitter, mournful, ominous, furious, defeated
Mixed	bittersweet, wistful, uneasy hope, comic menace, fragile confidence, ecstatic grief
Energy	restrained, simmering, driving, explosive, relentless, exhausted, weightless, ceremonial
Narrative tone	confessional, observational, surreal, satirical, devotional, confrontational, nostalgic
Scale	intimate, club-sized, live-room, cinematic, monumental, microscopic, cosmic

Performance vocabulary

Family	Vocabulary
Attack	soft, rounded, sharp, clipped, explosive, percussive, bowed, plucked
Articulation	legato, staccato, palm-muted, tremolo-picked, fingerpicked, pizzicato, sustained
Timing	tight, loose, behind the beat, ahead of the beat, swung, quantized, rubato
Density	solo, sparse, transparent, layered, dense, maximal, wall of sound
Movement	rising, falling, pulsing, breathing, lurching, floating, accelerating, collapsing
Interaction	unison, call and response, counterpoint, interlocking, antiphonal, trading solos

Recording and mix vocabulary

Family	Vocabulary
Distance	close-mic, intimate, room-mic, distant, cavernous, behind the band
Width	mono, narrow, center-focused, wide stereo, hard-panned, immersive
Frequency	dark, warm, mid-forward, bright, airy, bass-heavy, thin, band-limited
Dynamics	uncompressed, dynamic, gently compressed, punchy, dense, limited, pumping
Clarity	transparent, separated, crisp, detailed, hazy, blurred, muddy, abrasive
Surface	clean, polished, dusty, saturated, distorted, cracked, corroded, glossy
Space	dry, small room, chamber, hall, cathedral, plate, spring, infinite reverb
Era	1950s mono, 1960s psychedelic, 1970s analog, 1980s glossy, 1990s alternative, modern

Prompt checklist

- One dominant genre is obvious.
- Tempo or groove is specified when rhythm matters.
- Three to five defining instruments have clear roles.
- Voice includes range, texture, delivery, and ensemble role.
- Sections have an energy relationship, not merely names.
- Production includes only audible, compatible traits.
- The ending has an intentional instruction.
- Unwanted defaults are placed in Exclude.
- Lyrics use short readable lines and restrained section cues.
- The test changes one variable and generates multiple candidates.

Minimal master template

[primary genre] with [secondary trait], [tempo and groove], [three defining instruments], [vocal range + texture + delivery], [verse-to-chorus energy arc], [two or three production traits], [ending].

Advanced master template

[genre foundation], [era or scene], [BPM, groove, and meter], [drum behavior], [bass behavior], [foreground instruments and articulation], [other color instruments], [vocal identity], [vocal delivery and processing], [section contrast], [harmonic or melodic feature], [mix depth and width], [surface character], [ending].

17. Sources and evidence notes

Evidence boundary: Suno documents product controls and provides a general musical glossary. It does not publish a deterministic grammar for every style word or bracketed cue. Genre, instrument, vocal, and production effects in this guide therefore combine standard music terminology with practical prompting judgment. Treat them as probability-shaping language, not guaranteed commands.

Numbered sources

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Version note

Suno changes quickly. Interface labels, plan availability, model behavior, and feature limits may change after publication. The musical vocabulary remains useful, but current product claims should be checked against Suno's Help Center.

End of guide